



FRANCISCA NNEKA OKEKE

Nigerian physicist • 1956–present

After graduating from school, Francisca worked as a substitute teacher, filling in for other teachers when they were away. Francisca enjoyed posing and solving physics problems so much that she decided to study physics at university. This was not a popular choice for women at the time, but Francisca has helped to change this now.

Francisca became the first woman to lead the physics department at the University of Nigeria and has mentored dozens of young scientists. She has shown them that physics is not a difficult subject, but rather a fun and practical way to find answers to interesting questions.



As a child, Francisca was fascinated by the changing sky. Why was it sometimes white, but sometimes blue? How did airplanes stay up? By asking questions and seeking answers, Francisca raced ahead in science and math.